



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Travel nutrition guide: What to eat when your event is in a small town

Performance nutrition during travel is as **critical** as the training itself, especially in small towns, where food choices can be limited, cooking styles unpredictable, and access to specialised products inconsistent.

Athletes love the thrill of competing in different corners of India, but travel can become a hidden opponent that few prepare for. After working with athletes for two decades, across disciplines from boxing and athletics to cricket and shooting, I've learnt that performance nutrition during travel is as critical as the training itself. This is especially true in small towns, where food choices can be limited, cooking styles unpredictable, and access to specialised products inconsistent. Yet with the right strategy, athletes can thrive anywhere.

Travel days demand their own logic. Your gut, hydration, and energy levels are unusually vulnerable on the move. In India, travel often involves early morning flights, long train journeys, or road routes that swing between dusty highways and narrow town lanes. On these days, I advise every athlete to use a three-tier plan: secure, simple, safe. Secure your hydration by starting the day with clear fluids and oral rehydration. Keep meals simple by avoiding heavy *masalas* or street-fried foods. Choose safe foods you know you can tolerate, such as bananas, homemade rolls, pre-packed dry fruits, and your regular sports drink.

Several years ago, while accompanying young sprinters to a remote meet in northern Karnataka, I realised how easily travel companionship can derail discipline. One athlete once ate a harmless-looking plate of mixed street *chaat* during a travel halt. By race morning, hydration markers were poor, gut transit was sluggish, reaction time was slower, and race pace suffered. Since then, I make every athlete visualise the next day before choosing today's meal.

From then on, I have always guided my athletes with

three simple steps to stay on track while travelling.

First stop after landing: Buy safe food & water

As soon as you exit the airport or railway station, buy clean drinking water from a sealed bottle or trusted source. Travel quietly dehydrates you. Pick easy fruits you can peel and eat yourself, like bananas, apples, oranges, guava and grapes. Add a small pack of nuts and a bar of dark chocolate for steady energy and healthy fats. If your room has a fridge, a small tub of plain curd supports digestion.

Scout food options within 500m of your stay

After check-in, take a short walk around your hotel to identify one or two clean, simple restaurants nearby. This prevents last-minute panic eating. Look for plain rice, *rotis*, light *dal*, soup, grilled chicken or fish, and lightly cooked vegetables. Simple food keeps your gut calm and your energy steady.

Make one friendly food ally

Have a polite word with the chef or headwaiter and explain that you are an athlete and need low-oil, mild-spice food. Most kitchens are happy to support this. Simple